Plan a circle: “The Tell-Tale Heart”

Edgar Allan Poe (1843) · public-domain short story · grades 8–11 · ~1 week / two meetings. Rights: Public domain.

Kit section 5 (group agreement & calendar) filled in for one text — a finished plan students see before writing their own. ***Tinted italic*** = sample answers.

Text, group, and target

Text / author / edition	***“The Tell-Tale Heart” — Edgar Allan Poe (1843). Public-domain short story.***
Group / period / dates	***Omar’s group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___***
Grade / TEKS target (p. 3)	Grade 8 · §110.24 — 7(A): theme through characters/events; 6(C,D): support inferences; 1(D): student-led discussion.
Learning intention	We are learning to explain how the narrator’s unreliable voice reveals a theme about guilt and the mind.
Success criteria	I bring one open question, cite two details with locations, respond to a peer, and name how my thinking changed.

Reading map & calendar

Chunk	Read through	Meeting date · leader
1	***The plan, the seven nights of watching, and the killing.***	***Tue · Leader: Omar***
2	***The police visit and the confession.***	***Thu · Leader: Bea***

Members & first-meeting jobs (p. 7 roles)

Member	First job	Rotates to (next meeting)
Omar	***Questioner***	***Summarizer***
Bea	***Summarizer***	***Clarifier***
Kai	***Clarifier***	***Evidence tracker***
Zoe	***Predictor***	***Questioner***

Text-specific discussion questions (open — more than one answer)

- **Predict:** The narrator insists he is sane — what will his behavior reveal instead? What clue hints at it?
- **Question:** Why might Poe let the narrator tell his own story? How does that shape our trust?
- **Clarify:** What is the “beating” the narrator hears at the end — literal or guilt?
- **Summarize:** Order the events of the night of the murder, without opinion.
- **Interpret the theme:** How does the narrator’s voice reveal a theme about guilt or madness? Use two details.

> **Optional Jigsaw lenses (p. 4):** ***Character*** (the narrator) · ***Point of view*** (unreliable first person) · ***Language*** (repetition, dashes, exclamation) · ***Plot*** (control unraveling) · ***Theme*** (guilt and conscience).

Sample 3–2–1 notes: Kai, point of view lens

Name: Kai · Home group: Omar's group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___ · Section: "The Tell-Tale Heart," Chunk 2 · Expert lens: Point of view

> **What a finished prep looks like.** Kit section 6 / Organizer A completed for one reader, so students can compare their notes to a strong model.

Questions ***Is the narrator mad, or only guilty?*** ***Why confess when he had gotten away with it?***	**3 · Important ideas** ***1. The narrator claims sanity while describing obsession.*** ***2. He stalks the old man for seven nights before acting.*** ***3. He confesses under an imagined heartbeat.***
Vocabulary ***acute = sharp, heightened.*** ***dissimulation = hiding true feelings.***	**2 · Supporting details** ***1. His repeated "nervous — very, dreadfully nervous" (opening) undercuts the sanity claim.*** ***2. His shriek to the police (ending) shows guilt breaking through his control.***

1 · Summary in my own words

A narrator kills an old man over his "eye," hides the body, then confesses when he thinks he hears the heart.

Bring to the circle

My interpretation: ***The mind cannot escape its own guilt, no matter how it insists it is calm.***
Synthesis (two lenses): ***The unreliable narrator (point of view) proves the theme: his own telling exposes the guilt he denies. Text points: the sanity claim (Chunk 1) and the confession (Chunk 2).***
After discussion: ***My thinking became clearer once the group compared evidence.***

TEKS evidence: 6(C,D) supported inference; 7(A) theme through characters/events; 1(D) response to a peer. · Pair with the PlotPoint "The Tell-Tale Heart" room.